



Howard County
Office of Human Trafficking Prevention
Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council
2025 Report

Stronger connections. **Stronger futures.**

WORKING TOGETHER

The Office of Human Trafficking Prevention's mandate to work against sex and labor trafficking in Howard County is supported in part through the work of the **Howard County Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council** (HTPCC), an appointed and voluntary body which held its first meeting in December 2017. The HTPCC was made permanent by county legislation, (CB 52-2019) that took effect January 2020.

The Office of Human Trafficking Prevention aligns with the values and standards of the Maryland Human Trafficking Task Force, partnering with anti-trafficking agencies and organizations which conform responsibly to best practices in the field.



Calvin Ball
County Executive

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© HOWARD COUNTY DEPARTMENT OF COMMUNITY RESOURCES AND SERVICES

2025 ANNUAL REPORT

HOWARD COUNTY

Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council

Department of Community Resources and Services

OVERVIEW AND BACKGROUND

In 2014, Howard County commissioned its first Human Trafficking Task Force, which recommended expanding services for victims, increasing community-wide awareness and education, and strengthening coordination among county agencies and community-based organizations. In response, the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention (OHTP) was established within the Department of Community Resources and Services (DCRS) in 2017, along with an Executive Order creating the Howard County Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council (HTPCC). The council was charged with reviewing and prioritizing the 2014 Task Force recommendations and advising the county executive on sustainable structures to coordinate and strengthen anti-trafficking efforts.

The HTPCC began meeting in mid-2017 and was made permanent through county legislation in 2019 (CB 52-2019). Later that year, the HTPCC and DCRS issued a multi-year report outlining recommendations to guide future prevention and response efforts.

The HTPCC is a multidisciplinary body of residents, professionals and service providers dedicated to advancing awareness, education, survivor support, and cross-sector collaboration in partnership with OHTP. The council convenes regular full-council meetings and bi-monthly subcommittee meetings, working closely with partners across healthcare, homeless services and organizations serving foreign-born communities to strengthen prevention and response efforts throughout Howard County.

A Letter from the Chair of the HTPCC

2025 was an active year of stabilization, outreach, collaboration, and progress for the Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council..

The council strengthened its membership through the addition of new appointees from the community, including a survivor leader, and re-engaged with the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention through new appointments and reappointments. These additions have been well received and have helped enhance the council's leadership and perspective.

Throughout the year, our efforts focused on education and capacity building for both council members and the broader community. Human Trafficking Awareness and Prevention Month was particularly impactful, highlighted by the coordination of survivor organizations and partner agencies through the "Addressing the Vulnerabilities" event, which focused on the factors that increase risk for exploitation.

One of the council's most significant accomplishments this year was the re-establishment of its subcommittee structure. The three primary subcommittees — a) Legislative, b) Training, Outreach and Prevention (TOP), and the c) Screening and Assessment Tool — have provided a strong foundation for focused and strategic work. In addition, the CORE Team subcommittee continued to strengthen collaboration among affiliated agencies and partners, improving coordination throughout the year.

As we look ahead to 2026 and beyond, the council intends to maximize its partnerships to become more action-oriented and solutions-focused, while continuing to support the work of the Howard County Office of Human Trafficking Prevention. Through our subcommittee structure, we anticipate refining a countywide Data Collection Tool to support ethical and consistent reporting, implementing a standardized Screening and Assessment Tool to improve early identification of trafficking victims, and expanding our public policy role through increased engagement and recommendations to the county executive aimed at strengthening survivor protections and reducing vulnerabilities.

Respectfully,

Chuck Chandler
2025 HTPCC Chair



Human Trafficking Data and Trends in Howard County

Data collected in 2025 from law enforcement and direct service providers reflect the continued presence of human trafficking in Howard County and highlight the importance of coordinated prevention, identification, and response efforts across systems. While each data source represents a different point of entry — law enforcement intervention and voluntary service engagement — together they provide a more comprehensive understanding of trafficking trends, locations, and service needs within the county.

Law Enforcement Trends

Based on quarterly reporting from the Howard County Police Department (HCPD), 35 new victims of sex trafficking were recovered and offered services during calendar year 2025. These cases were identified across hotel-based, residential and illicit massage business (IMB) settings, with IMB-related investigations increasing in the latter part of the year.

Direct Service Provider Trends

Service-provider data further illustrates the scope and complexity of trafficking-related needs in the county. In 2025, direct service providers served 48 new individuals, including survivors of trafficking and individuals identified as being at high risk. The majority experienced sex trafficking, with labor trafficking and combined forms also identified. A significant portion were classified as high risk, underscoring the value of early identification and prevention-focused engagement before exploitation escalates. Consistent with law enforcement trends, hotel-based, residential, and IMB-related settings were the most commonly identified locations of exploitation.

Data Context

It is important to note that human trafficking remains significantly underreported, and available data reflect only known and identified cases. Differences in reporting timelines, survivor choice, and system access influence how data are captured across agencies. An increase in identification numbers does not necessarily indicate that more trafficking is occurring in Howard County; rather, it often reflects improved training, stronger cross-sector coordination, enhanced investigative capacity, and increased community awareness. In this context, a rise in identified cases can represent progress in recognizing and responding to exploitation. Continued investment in training, outreach and collaborative systems is essential to ensure that individuals experiencing trafficking are identified earlier and connected to appropriate services.

Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council

REPRESENTED MEMBERSHIP

The HTPCC consists of 19 to 23 members and designees.

Representative from the Director of the
Department of Community Resources and ServicesJacqueline R. Scott, JD, ML

Representative from the Administrator of the
Office of Human Rights and Equity LaKeisha McClendon

Representative from the State’s Attorney’s Office..... Richard Gibson

Representative from the Chief of Police Chief Gregory Der

Representative from the Howard County Commission for Women Diana Awed

Representative from the Director of the Department of Social Services Geneva Rieu, LCSW-C

Health Officer or the Health Officer’s designee Ilise D. Marrazzo, MPH, RN

Representative from the Sheriff’s Department..... Dina Ward

Representative from the Howard County Public School System..... Ivan Croft, PhD, NCSP

Appointed members of the private sector shall include at least:

Two representatives from the faith-based community Vinitha Nithianandam
Fr. Travis K. Smith

Representative from HoCo AGAST (Howard County Advocacy Group
Against Slavery and Trafficking) or similar group who providing
intervention and advocacy on behalf of human trafficking victims Sara Cochran

Representative from HopeWorks Ngozi Obineme

Representative from a non-profit agency providing
services to human trafficking survivors (TurnAround, Inc.) *appointment pending*

Representative from Grassroots Crisis Intervention Center; *appointment pending*

Representative from the Howard County General Hospital *appointment pending*

Two representatives from the survivor community Liz Kimbel

Representative from the general public Mack Bowles
Stephen Conti, LMT
Tahira Mussarat Hussain
Tina Horn, IOM

Representative from the business community..... Chuck Chandler

Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council

ACTIVITIES, HIGHLIGHTS AND TRAININGS

Subcommittees

In 2025, the HTPCC successfully reestablished its subcommittee structure. All subcommittees were formally established and began meeting regularly throughout the latter part of the year. These subcommittees were designed to support focused, action-oriented work aligned with the council's mandate, while allowing members to engage deeply in specific priority areas.

CORE Team Subcommittee

The CORE Team Subcommittee serves as a collaborative forum for direct service providers and system partners to coordinate around human trafficking trends, service gaps, and system-level challenges in Howard County. Originally established through the Office for Victims of Crime (OVC) Enhanced Collaborative Model (ECM), the CORE Team provides structured space for case-informed discussion while maintaining strict confidentiality standards.

In 2025, the CORE Team met six times throughout the year, continuing its role as a multidisciplinary body focused on coordinated case review and systems collaboration. Current member agencies include: Howard County Police Department, TurnAround, Inc., HopeWorks, OHTP, and the Child Advocacy Center. The subcommittee welcomed a new partner from the Department of Social Services, Child Protective Services (CPS), strengthening cross-system coordination, particularly in youth-related cases.

Throughout the year, members discussed emerging trafficking trends and identified gaps in services impacting survivors and individuals at risk. The CORE Team also worked collaboratively to establish and refine a countywide Data Collection Tool to improve reporting consistency, trend analysis, and data-informed decision-making across agencies.

All participating members have signed confidentiality agreements to ensure the secure and ethical handling of case information. The continued convening of this group strengthens interagency communication, supports trauma-informed and survivor-centered practices, and advances a more coordinated system of care for survivors in Howard County.

Legislative Subcommittee

The Legislative Subcommittee monitors and reviews local, state and federal policy developments related to human trafficking, labor exploitation and victim protections. The subcommittee ensures the council remains informed and responsive to legislative changes that impact prevention efforts and service delivery.

Its goals include tracking relevant legislation, providing policy updates and recommendations to the full council, identifying opportunities for recommendation and education, and supporting informed strategic planning.

Training, Outreach and Prevention (TOP) Subcommittee

The TOP Subcommittee strengthens the capacity of professionals and community members across Howard County to recognize, prevent and respond to human trafficking. The subcommittee integrates training, outreach and prevention strategies by identifying priority audiences, coordinating trauma-informed and survivor-informed education, and promoting consistent prevention messaging across sectors.

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In 2025, the TOP Subcommittee supported several targeted training initiatives across key systems. These efforts included training more than 300 Student Support Staff within the Howard County Public School System (HCPSS), strengthening school-based awareness of trafficking indicators, student vulnerabilities, and appropriate reporting and referral pathways. The subcommittee also supported human trafficking training for leadership staff at the Howard County Department of Corrections, increasing awareness of trafficking dynamics, victim identification, and trauma-informed response within the correctional setting. In addition, training was delivered to public health nurses, enhancing their ability to recognize indicators of trafficking in healthcare settings and connect individuals to appropriate services.

Beyond professional training, the subcommittee advances community-based prevention efforts by engaging populations most vulnerable to exploitation, supporting culturally responsive outreach strategies, distributing educational resources, and strengthening cross-sector collaboration to address vulnerabilities before harm occurs.

Screening and Assessment Tool Subcommittee

The Screening and Assessment Tool Subcommittee was established to support the development of a standardized, countywide tool to improve the early identification of individuals experiencing or at risk of human trafficking. The subcommittee brings together cross-sector stakeholders to ensure the tool is trauma-informed, ethically grounded, and responsive to the realities of direct service providers.

The subcommittee's goals include promoting consistent identification and response practices across agencies, incorporating survivor-informed and provider-informed feedback, and strengthening responsible data collection and referral pathways. To support this work, members are actively reviewing existing screening tools and assessments used within the anti-trafficking field, with a focus on evidence-based and expert-recommended practices to inform local implementation.

Human Trafficking Awareness and Prevention Month 2025

In January 2025, in recognition of Human Trafficking Prevention Month, the Human Trafficking Prevention and Coordination Council (HTPCC) hosted a resource fair themed "Addressing the Vulnerabilities." The event was designed to move beyond awareness and focus on the structural and individual vulnerabilities that increase risk for exploitation. Participating agencies were each assigned a specific vulnerability, such as housing instability, immigration status, economic insecurity, healthcare access, or system involvement, and attendees rotated between tables to learn how these factors impact a survivor's ability to access resources and how agencies work to address these barriers.

The event included participation from a range of Howard County agencies and community partners, including the Office of Human Rights and Equity, HopeWorks, Grassroots Crisis Intervention Center, Luminis, the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention, the Department of Community Resources and Services (DCRS), the Howard County Health Department (including HIV Prevention, Reproductive Health, Overdose Response, and Behavioral Health teams), Hon's Honey, and Ayuda.

The program also featured a Human Trafficking 101 presentation with a focused emphasis on labor trafficking, followed by a partial screening of *Food Chains*, which highlighted exploitation within agricultural labor systems and efforts to hold corporations accountable through worker empowerment. The screening was followed by an expert panel discussion examining labor trafficking in Howard County, populations most impacted, and strategies to strengthen survivor support. Collectively, the event reinforced the importance of coordinated, prevention-focused, and vulnerability-informed approaches to addressing human trafficking at the local level.

Ongoing Goals

These goals reflect the Council's ongoing commitment to fostering a coordinated, inclusive, and survivor-informed approach to preventing human trafficking in Howard County.

Centering Survivor Voices

Integrate survivor leadership and lived-experience perspectives into council initiatives, training development and policy recommendations to ensure trauma-informed and survivor-informed approaches.

Enhance Community Collaboration

Expand and deepen cross-sector partnerships with local agencies, council, commissions, and neighboring jurisdictions to strengthen prevention and response efforts.

Advance Awareness for Vulnerabilities to Trafficking

Expand outreach efforts to meet the needs of populations most vulnerable to human trafficking, using best-practice, victim-centered approaches that prioritize cultural responsiveness and equity.

Enhance Council Capacity

Work closely with county administration to fill vacant council appointments and ensure a fully representative, engaged and effective membership body.

Events for Human Trafficking Prevention and Awareness Month

Begin work on planning a council-led event for January 2027.

New Goals for 2026

As the HTPCC reflects on the progress made throughout 2025, it remains committed to advancing its original recommendations while setting forth new goals that will guide its work in 2026. Looking ahead, the council will focus on the following priorities:

Strengthening Data Collection Tool

Refine and enhance the County's Data Collection Tool to ensure ethical, consistent reporting and improved analysis of trends and service gaps.

Create a County-wide Screening and Assessment Tool

Create and implement a standardized, trauma-informed screening tool to improve early identification of trafficking victims and ensure consistent responses across agencies.

Expanding Social Media and Public Awareness Efforts

Strengthen digital outreach and public messaging to increase awareness of trafficking indicators and available resources in Howard County.

Expand Policy Impact

Monitor and support implementation of state and federal legislation while identifying local policy opportunities to reduce vulnerabilities and improve survivor protections.

IN CONCLUSION

In 2025, the Howard County Human Trafficking Prevention Coordination Council continued to build on prior outreach, training and collaborative efforts while placing increased emphasis on strengthening internal infrastructure, survivor-informed leadership, and coordinated prevention strategies. In partnership with the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention, the council supported a range of training and educational initiatives reaching school-based professionals, public health staff, law enforcement, corrections leadership, and other frontline systems across Howard County. These efforts reinforced awareness of trafficking indicators, prevention strategies, and response pathways across multiple sectors.

Recognizing the importance of survivor leadership, the council advanced efforts to center lived experience within its work. In 2025, the appointment of a survivor leader to the HTPCC marked a significant milestone in strengthening survivor-informed decision-making and ethical practice across council activities. This progress reflects the council's continued commitment to ensuring survivor perspectives shape prevention, outreach and policy discussions.

Internally, the HTPCC made substantial progress in reestablishing its subcommittee structure and strengthening council capacity through new appointments and reappointments. Regular subcommittee convenings supported focused work on policy, training, outreach, data, and systems coordination, positioning the council for more targeted and measurable outcomes in the year ahead.

Together, these efforts reflect the HTPCC's ongoing dedication to fostering a coordinated, inclusive, and prevention-focused approach to human trafficking prevention in Howard County. As the council looks ahead to 2026, it remains committed to building on this foundation through survivor-informed leadership, strengthened partnerships, data-informed strategies, and sustained collaboration across county systems and the broader community.



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If you need this information in an alternate format, contact the Office of Human Trafficking Prevention at 410-313-6558 (voice/relay) or ohtp@howardcountymd.gov.